updation into its sharpest weapon for the 2026 assembly poll. Visual proof came on an overcast December morning, as M.K. Stalin walked into a booth committee meeting in Alwarpet. Now, Division 24 of Mylapore is not a place where chief ministers typically spend their mornings. But this was different. This was going to be a command briefing—not in a remote war room, but right at the front.

BOOTH AS FORTRESS

He was officially launching the second phase of the DMK's statewide 'My Booth, Victory Booth' campaign, a mobilisation effort designed to turn every polling station into fortified battlements. His intent was to demonstrate the tactical doctrine that the SIR has pretty much handed out to the DMK. To wit, that the battle for votes would be fought not in rallies or motorcades but at the smallest, most intimate unit of democratic life: the booth.

Even when the SIR was in its first phase, the Dravidian party had loudly, repeatedly and publicly opposed it—

Takeaways

- **DMK has trained and deployed 680,000 booth committee members; MPs and MLAs join local party office-bearers for vigil**
- **With 'My Booth, Victory Booth', Stalin has laid out clear micro-targets for each of TN's 68,463 booths. The aim is to outperform 2021**

Stalin even travelled to Bihar in August to join INDIA allies in a rally against the first edition of what later became a national-level mass voter revision. That arms him with ammo as the war comes home. In Tamil Nadu, the SIR has been a point of deep contention for months. The DMK questioned its timing, its need and its potential consequences so close to major elections.

Hurried revision, its leaders argued, risked disenfranchising genuine voters by placing an unreasonable procedural burden on them. With accusations of institutional bias, they say, it appears more like a battle siege on enemy fortresses—with Booth Level Officers (BLOs) turned, unwittingly or not, into advance raiding parties hunting for weaknesses along all ramparts.

Yet, recognising that the revision would proceed regardless of political objections, Stalin executed a tactical pivot to turn liability into strength. The DMK has deployed 680,000 booth committee members to assist BLOs and voters, turning it into a mass contact programme. After a sluggish start, it soon gathered statewide momentum. The DMK is now using it as a wholesale boot camp for its organisation.

GROUND OPERATION

For a month beginning December 10, DMK squads will visit all 68,463 booths across Tamil Nadu to craft booth-specific strategies. Party briefings suggest a massive scale. Over 1,900 zonal, union, city and town panchayat secretaries have been conscripted; they will be joined by 78 district secretaries, 33 MPs, 124 MLAs and state and district office-bearers.

The aim: systematic voter verification, and morale-boosting for the 680,000 footsoldiers. At every stop, cadres hear the same instruction: each booth must outperform its 2021 numbers. Stalin offered a live demo at Alwarpet. He set a precise target of 440 votes for that booth, breaking it down into individual micro-responsibilities.

The rhetoric was soon giving air support to the ground operation. The catalyst for it was Union home minister Amit Shah's scheduled visit—though deferred once on December 15, it set speculation swirling around the political churn it might trigger.

That became an occasion for Stalin to let go of a fusillade: the DMK's "black and red shirts", he wrote on X, would "confront the Shahs of Delhi", saying Tamil Nadu has always resisted northern subjugation. State BJP spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathy reciprocated in kind, tweeting: "Any Stalin with the mindset of the 'Russian Stalin' will be taught a lesson." But what the state BJP is really hoping for is that Shah will come and mend the wobbly alliance with the AIADMK. ■

UPDATING THE ROLLS A house-to-house verification in progress under the SIR process in Thoothukudi, Nov. 4

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